



# THE MORNING KICKOFF

📍 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Final countdown: two days to Spain–Argentina at MetLife



Sunday, 21:00 our time: Spain–Argentina — the 37-game streak against the champions



First, Saturday 23:00: France–England for third place — and maybe the Golden Boot



Kalshi this morning: final money at Spain 43, Tie 32, Argentina 27 — \$1.1m traded

⚡ TWO DAYS TO THE FINAL · SPAIN–ARGENTINA

## THE STREAK MEETS THE DYNASTY.

No football today — just the numbers gathering weight. Spain bring a 37-match unbeaten run across all competitions and the stingiest defence in World Cup history. Argentina bring a 13-game unbeaten World Cup streak, a 39-year-old rewriting endings, and the chance to become the first back-to-back champions since Brazil in 1962. Two days. One trophy. And before it, a Golden Boot playoff in Miami.

### ALSO THIS MORNING

- ⚡ Team news: Yamal has been managing hamstring trouble but remains central to everything Spain do. Argentina came through Atlanta without a fresh injury concern.
- ⚙ The Boot: Messi's two Atlanta assists bolster his tie-break, but Mbappé strikes first — Saturday against England, one goal for the outright lead.
- ★ The Crystal Ball returns tomorrow with the third-place call, then Sunday morning with the big one. Record so far: 5 winners from 9, two exact scores.

### INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 The final weekend previewed with fresh prices — Miami Saturday, MetLife Sunday
- P.3 Golden Boot: Messi 8, Mbappé 8 — the tie-break maths, and who plays when
- P.4 The completed bracket, the last week strip, and what happens after Sunday



Lamine Yamal — managing a hamstring, carrying Spain's right flank, two days from the biggest game of his life

THE FINAL WEEKEND (CENTRAL EUROPE)



France  
–  
England



Sat  
23:00



Spain –  
Argentina



Sun  
21:00

FULL  
PREVIEWS →  
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THIRD PLACE · TOMORROW · MIAMI

France

VS

England

Sat 23:00

Kick-off 5:00 PM ET at the stadium

Hard Rock Stadium, Miami

The bronze nobody craves, the Boot everybody watches. Mbappé and Dembélé get one more night to add to 8 and 5; Kane (5) and Bellingham (4) get one last England shift of the summer. The market has hardened French: 51% against 25 for England, with 26 on the draw — England's response to Atlanta, four days on, is the great unknown. The Crystal Ball makes its third-place call tomorrow morning.

- Mbappé: one goal for the outright Golden Boot lead — and first swing, a day before Messi**
- Tuchel's selection — how much does a shattered England rotate for a bronze medal?**
- Third-place games are traditionally goal-fests — the last four produced three or more goals each**



KEY MAN · ENGLAND

Harry Kane

Five goals, one game left in an England shirt this summer. A hat-trick in Miami would tie the leaders — unlikely, but this is the fixture where strange things happen.

THE FINAL · SUNDAY · METLIFE

Spain

VS

Argentina

Sun 21:00

Kick-off 3:00 PM ET at the stadium

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

Thirty-seven games unbeaten against thirteen World Cup games unbeaten — something breaks Sunday. Spain have conceded twice all tournament and suffocated France; Argentina have spent three straight knockouts proving no lead against them is safe. Yamal, nursing that hamstring, against Messi, nursing history. The money keeps drifting Spanish: 43 to 27 with 32 on the draw, and over a million dollars down.

- Yamal v Messi — the heir and the throne share a pitch with the trophy between them**
- Álvarez against the record wall — Pickford stopped him twice; Simón is a different question**
- Argentina's stoppage-time sorcery against a Spain side that has never trailed this tournament**



KEY MAN · ARGENTINA

Julián Álvarez

The 112th-minute winner against Switzerland, denied twice by Pickford in Atlanta. Against a wall this good, Argentina need their spider to bite once.

SPAIN-ARGENTINA: THE BACK CATALOGUE

They almost never meet — and when they do, someone gets hurt

|                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div> </div> <div> Argentina </div> <div> 2 – 1 </div> <div> Spain </div> <div> </div> <div> England 66 · group </div>    | <div> </div> <div> Argentina </div> <div> 4 – 1 </div> <div> Spain </div> <div> </div> <div> 2010 friendly </div>    |
| <div> </div> <div> Spain </div> <div> 6 – 1 </div> <div> Argentina </div> <div> </div> <div> 2018 · Isco hat-trick </div> | <div> </div> <div> Spain </div> <div> ? – ? </div> <div> Argentina </div> <div> </div> <div> Sunday · MetLife </div> |

TOMORROW: THE THIRD-PLACE CRYSTAL BALL — FRANCE-ENGLAND, MIAMI, 23:00 CET



8

### Lionel Messi

Plays the final Sunday — assists have his tie-break covered



8

### Kylian Mbappé

Third place Saturday — likely needs a goal, not a tie



7

### Erling Haaland

Eliminated — his race ended one goal short



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Messi's two Atlanta assists strengthen his case in a tie — which makes a Mbappé goal on Saturday almost mandatory.

## ⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

37

Matches unbeaten for Spain across all competitions going into Sunday

13

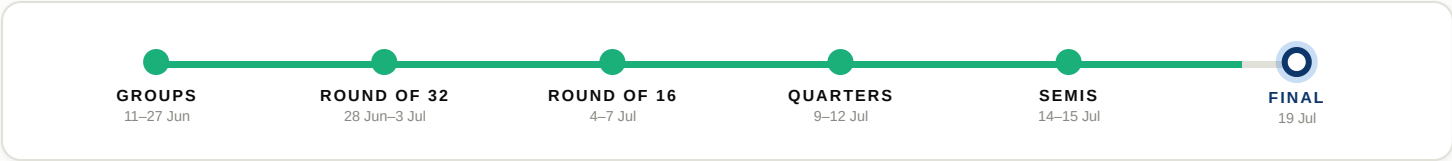
World Cup matches unbeaten for Argentina — eleven wins, two draws

\$1.1m

Traded on the final on Kalshi by this morning — Spain 43, Tie 32, Argentina 27

4th

The star Argentina are chasing — and it would be the first repeat since Brazil 1962

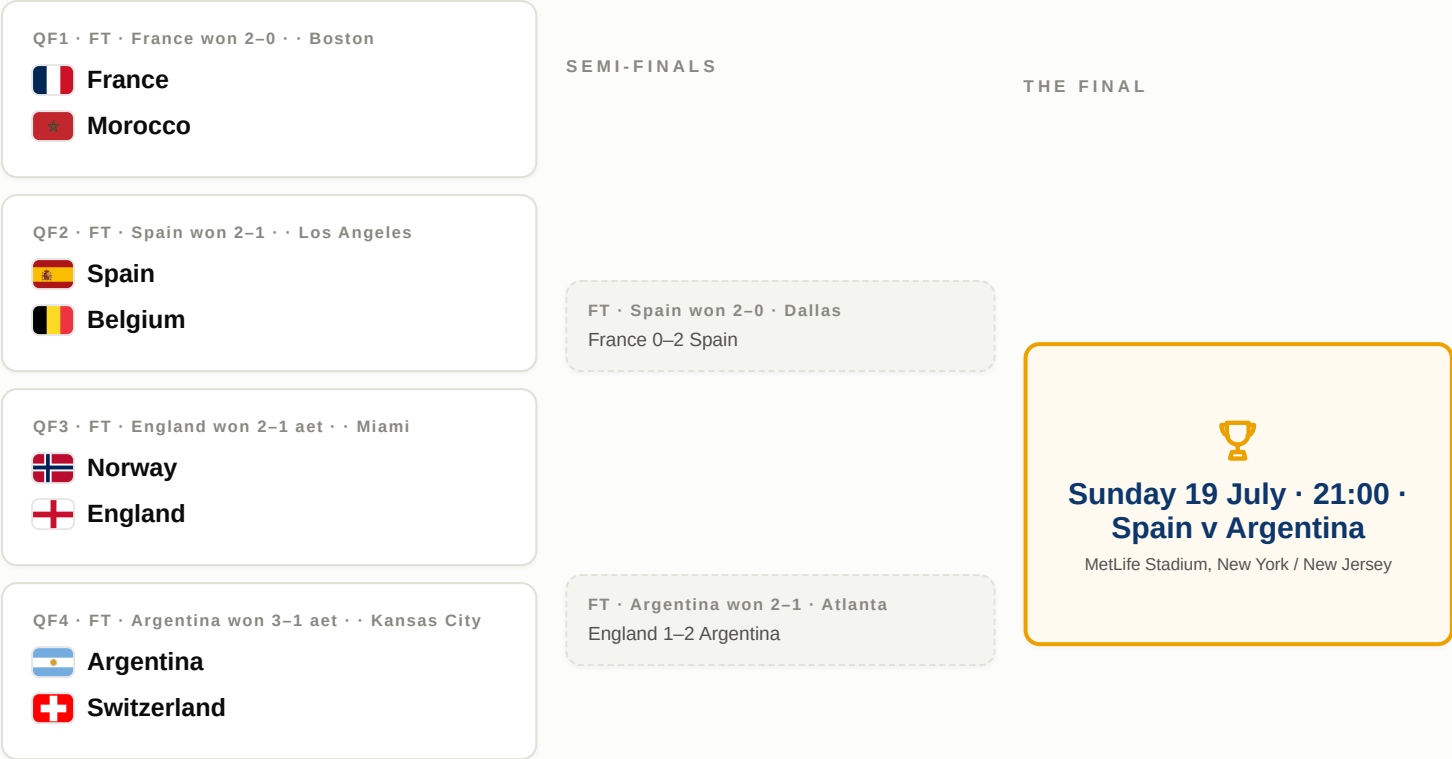




KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9–12 July · Semi-finals 14–15 July

QUARTER-FINALS





YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Wednesday 15 July — the trophy on Sunday 19 July



See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: the third-place Crystal Ball, the Golden Boot showdown, and final-eve team news from both camps.